

Reviewer comments on proposed book
Social Identity and Music:
A Search for Moral Autonomy and Personhood in Pop Culture

The manuscript aims to integrate multiple fields into a sustained philosophical account of how narratives—including those of popular music—shape identity, agency, moral understanding, and flourishing. The author presents narrative as a form of “moral testimony,” arguing that emotionally rich narratives have can be used to convey the affective components of moral knowledge, and drawing on the sentimentalist perspectives of contemporary philosophers such as Slote and Zagzebski. Most interestingly, the author takes this argument to popular music. The author also incorporates literature from psychology in considering the construct of identity.

Recommendation on Publication

I begin here with my recommendation and will continue by presenting my rationale for this recommendation. I recommend that Vernon Press *provisionally accept* this manuscript for publication *subject to changes*. My comments below are offered toward the revision effort toward this end.

Strengths of the Proposal

Chief among the strengths of this manuscript is that it tackles an ambitious and understudied intersection—moral testimony, narrative identity, and popular music—bringing together philosophical, psychological, and cultural-theoretical literature in a way that is both intellectually wide-ranging and conceptually integrated. The author shows clear command of sentimentalist ethical theory, particularly care-based approaches, and effectively connects these frameworks to contemporary discussions of empathy, affect, and narrative agency. The work is strongest when articulating how narratives, including those found in popular music, can function as sources of moral knowledge and identity formation. These discussions are original, timely, and likely to appeal to readers in moral philosophy, aesthetics, narrative psychology, and cultural studies.

Suggestions for Improvement of Quality of Scholarship

Originality (Rating of 2 on scale of 1-3)

The manuscript takes up questions that remain timely across the fields of psychology, aesthetics, social identity theory, and popular music studies. The author’s attempt to bridge sentimentalist moral philosophy with cultural analysis is promising, and the project’s ambition is clear. Still, the manuscript would benefit from a sharper articulation of what is genuinely new here, as opposed to what extends existing conversations. At present, the reader must infer the contribution rather than having it explicitly framed. Strengthening the positioning of the work within current scholarship—especially recent developments in narrative identity, empathy research, and pop-cultural epistemology—would help clarify both the currency and the distinctiveness of the author’s thesis.

Rigor (Rating of 2 on scale of 1-3)

My chief concern related to rigor is that the manuscript reads much like a doctoral dissertation. Its arguments would be more persuasive to a broader readership with tighter organization and more explicit framing of the arguments. For example, some sections read more like stand-alone essays, in that each section addresses an issue to a resolution, but it does so internally rather than by transitioning from what preceded it and setting the reader up for what follows. Also, some key terms deserve more plainly given definitions, and definitions that are consistently adhered to throughout, e.g., narrative, moral testimony, sentimentalism, and identity. Occasionally the author presents intriguing claims but ones that need better supporting evidence or grounding in the literature. A more disciplined structure would help the reader greatly. Also beneficial would be if each chapter explicitly presents its purpose (rather than just previewing what it will contain) and explains its connection to the broader argument. Finally, I would appreciate greater precision in distinguishing philosophical analysis from psychological/empirical principles.

Impact (Rating of 2 on scale of 1-3)

The manuscript has the potential to speak to multiple scholarly communities. Its impact would, however, be heightened by a clearer sense of audience and application. In its current form, this manuscript shifts between philosophical theory, cultural criticism, and psychological application without clearly indicating how readers in each area might use its insights. This is not my area of expertise, but I would speculate that readers would be interested to know how the author’s contributions relate to certain “hot topics,” such as the morality of fiction in the dramatic arts (including literature) and the role of popular culture in shaping people’s individual and group identities. I would encourage the author to clarify who most needs this book, and how its arguments advance conversations across the disciplines with which it intersects. Finally, the manuscript has virtually no visual aids (figures/charts/illustrations). I’m not exactly sure what is needed in this way, but in general, I think such visual displays are appreciated by readers.

Overall, I found this manuscript to be thoughtful and generally well-written. It engages well with both philosophical and psychological literatures. I found no issues with factual accuracy, nor did I encounter anything that struck me as libelous, defamatory, or otherwise problematic. While I have offered suggestions intended to strengthen the book's clarity, structure, and contribution, these are offered in the spirit of collegial support for a project that holds real promise. The author's commitment to the topic is evident throughout, and with refinement, this work has the potential to make a meaningful contribution the literature about narrative, identity, and moral understanding.